

# HASHKAMA WEEKLY

פרשת בהר-בחוקתי  
כא' אייר תשפ"ו  
MAY 8, 2026  
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## By Reb Gemini חכמה ב-א תאמין?

Consider the following "Torah" thought, generated by Gemini:  
Did the AI get it right? Do you find

it to be accurate? Or did the technology miss the boat?

Rabosai, in Parshas Behar (Vayikra 25:17), the Torah warns, "Velo sonu ish es amiso," which Chazal in Bava Metzia (58b) define as the issur of Ona'as Devarim. The Gemara gives a remarkably specific example: a person must not ask a merchant, "Kama cheifetz zeh?" if he has absolutely no intention of opening his wallet. We all know that one fellow who treats the local seforim gesheft like an interactive museum. He will saunter in, lean over the counter, and ask the exhausted mocher for the exact retail price of a hand-tooled leather Shas, fully knowing he is only in the store to wait out the heavy rain. This halacha teaches us that another Yid's time and financial expectations are not our personal playground. The Torah demands complete authenticity in our daily interactions; we cannot engage in a superficial kibitz that leaves another feeling manipulated. It is a severe aveirah precisely because the emotional damage is completely invisible to everyone else. This is why the passuk concludes with "veyareisa me'elokecha," because only the Eibershter knows the exact kavanah in your heart when you spent twenty minutes negotiating the price of a sterling silver becher you never planned to purchase. This strict demand for uncompromising authenticity perfectly sets up the opening of Parshas Bechukosai. The passuk states, "Im bechukosai telechu" (Vayikra 26:3), and Rashi famously quotes the Toras Kohanim to explain this phrase: "Shetiheyu ameilim baTorah." Why does the Torah use the word "telechu," which implies walking or moving, to describe the stationary, desk-bound act of learning? The answer connects seamlessly to our window-shopping friend from Parshas Behar. Just as the Torah forbids non-committal inquiries in matters of gashmiyus, it completely rejects the exact same lackadaisical approach in ruchniyus. You cannot simply waltz into the Beis Midrash, casually ask the nearest chavrusa "Kama cheifetz zeh?" regarding a highly complicated Rashba, and then immediately stroll back out to the coffee room once your curiosity is satisfied. Ameilus means you are a serious buyer, not a passing spiritual tourist. True "telechu" requires a sweat-inducing, genuine commitment to immerse yourself in the sugya. When we successfully merge the lessons of these two parshiyos, we realize that whether dealing with a heavily stressed retail owner or an incredibly difficult Tosafos, the Eibershter expects absolute kavanah. We must invest our entire essence rather than lazily browsing the shelves for a quick thrill. **Practical takeaway:** This week, make a conscious effort to pick one specific area of your daily routine where you have been functioning as a mere casual spectator and force yourself to become a fully invested participant. If you are learning a difficult masechta, do not casually skim the pages, nod approvingly, and assume you understand the depth of the machlokes; sit down, break your teeth on the actual text, and stubbornly review the core sevara until you truly own it. Similarly, if you are talking to a fellow mispallel after Maariv, do not just offer a painfully generic greeting while subtly looking over his shoulder to see who else is walking through the shul's double doors. Look him straight in the eye, ask him how his week is going, and actually stand there quietly, long enough to actively listen to his answer.

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## Shabbus Zmanim

Chestnut Ridge, NY

2:30 pm מנחה

6:32/7:43 pm (Early/Late) הדלקה

מנחה - קבלת שבת 7:00 pm

8:01 pm שקיעה

4:08/4:32 am (16.1/72) עלות השחר

5:44 am נץ החמה

7:15 am שחרית

Hot kiddush & Shiur after davening

8:43/9:19 am ס"ז קריאת שמע

10:06/10:30 am ס"ז תפילה

12:53 pm חצות היום

1:28 pm מנחה גדולה (גר"א)

5:03 pm מנחה קטנה (גר"א)

6:32 pm פלג המנחה (גר"א)

מנחה 7:00 pm

8:02 pm שקיעה

8:48/8:52 pm (8.5/50) צה"כ ר' משה

8:54 pm מעריב (52)

9:02/9:14 pm (60/72) צה"כ



## Next Week's Zmanim

Chestnut Ridge, NY

2:30 pm מנחה

6:37/7:50 pm (Early/Late) הדלקה

8:08 pm שקיעה

7:15 am שחרית

8:09 pm שקיעה

9:01 pm מעריב (52)

## This Week's Riddle

**Riddle:** In this Parsha, what number appears four times in one pasuk?

**Answer:** The number seven appears four times in the pasuk: "Count for yourselves seven sets of Sabbatical years, and it should be seven sets of Sabbatical years" (Vayikra 25:8).



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## משל ונמשל ב-AI תאמין?

By Reb Gemini

Consider the following "Torah" thought, generated by Gemini: Did the AI get it right? Do you find it to be accurate? Or did the technology miss the boat?

**Mashal:** Rabosai, imagine the typical scene in our beloved shul on a freezing Friday afternoon in the middle of Teves. We all know a certain balabos—let us call him Reb Fishel—who is absolutely convinced that he is the undisputed mumche of the shul's archaic, overly complicated HVAC system and its accompanying analog Shabbos clock. The gabbai has explicitly posted a large, bold sign that says "Do Not Touch," but Reb Fishel is deeply certain that the shul's entire thermal equilibrium rests squarely on his narrow shoulders. He stands there with a flathead screwdriver and a tactical flashlight, intensely adjusting the tiny metal pins on the giant brass dial, convinced that if he moves the three o'clock pin exactly one millimeter to the left, the heat in the ezras nashim will finally be perfectly balanced for the Nashim during leining. He sweats, he calculates, he mutters under his breath about thermodynamic airflow, putting in massive amounts of exhausting hishtadlus. He truly thinks he is running the building. What Reb Fishel does not know is that three weeks ago, the professional plumber completely bypassed that broken mechanical clock and wired the entire building to a computerized smart thermostat hidden inside the gabbai's locked office. Reb Fishel is aggressively twisting dials, stressing himself out, and taking immense pride in the ambient temperature, completely unaware that his frantic tinkering is absolutely meaningless and that the real control lies with a master system he cannot even see, managed by someone else entirely.

**Nimshal:** This comical illusion of control is the exact yesod connecting the dual parshiyos of Behar and Bechukosai. In Parshas Behar, the Torah commands us regarding the tremendous mitzvah of Shmita (Vayikra 25:4), demanding that we let the land completely rest. The Eibershter perfectly knows our nature; He anticipates our human panic and addresses it directly: "Vechol tomru mah nochal bashanah hashvi'is?" (Vayikra 25:20). We panic because, exactly like Reb Fishel, we think our physical plowing and planting—our frantic twisting of the earthly dials—is what actually creates our parnassah. Shmita forces us to step back from the loud machinery of hishtadlus and realize that the Master of the Universe is running the hidden thermostat. When we fail to internalize this profound bitachon, we stumble directly into the terrifying tochachah of Parshas Bechukosai. There, the passuk warns us repeatedly about the devastating, terrifying consequences of walking with the Eibershter "bekeri" (Vayikra 26:27-28). The Rambam in Hilchos Taaniyos (1:3) explains that "keri" means treating the events of this world as mere happenstance, natural coincidence, or the direct results of our own brilliant strategic maneuvers. If we stubbornly believe that our personal business acumen, our diverse stock portfolios, and our endless hours at the office are the true source of our hatzlachah, Hashem says He will simply leave us to the merciless whims of that very "keri." We are stripped of His hashgachah pratis. Shmita teaches us to drop the screwdriver and trust the hidden system, while Bechukosai warns us that stubbornly clinging to the illusion of our own control is the root of all spiritual disaster.

**Practical Takeaway:** The practical takeaway for every single one of us this week is to actively identify our own personal Shabbos clock—the specific area in our lives where we are putting in an unhealthy, obsessive level of hishtadlus under the false impression that we are completely in charge. Whether it is frantically checking your inbox forty times an hour during a tense business negotiation, micromanaging a shidduch for your older child to the point of absolute exhaustion for both the shadchan and yourselves, or staying up all night obsessing over every minor fluctuating percentage in your Vanguard index funds, you must take a deliberate step back. Make a conscious, ironclad kabbalah to close the laptop, put away the smartphone, and mentally hand the keys back to the Eibershter. When you feel that familiar knot of anxiety tightening in your chest, explicitly say out loud, "Hashem, this is Your parnassah, this is Your shidduch, and You are exclusively running the world." By artificially creating our own miniature Shmita in our daily routines and stepping away from the heavy machinery of hishtadlus, we guarantee that we walk with Hashem in absolute emunah, and in return, we will undoubtedly be zocheh to the incredible berachos promised in Parshas Bechukosai.

# GOOD SHABBUS!